

Playing and editing Music or Audio

Linux has many applications for playing music and it's also really taken off as a platform for audiophiles. If you are a budding DJ, or play with MIDI instruments, Linux is a great operating system to use. There is a wealth of software available today which exceeds the requirements of many a Cubase user, and all for free!

First things first – 'Codec' licensing, or, 'Why the heck can't I play some audio files or movies'?

If you have just started using Ubuntu, you may notice that if you try to play some types of music or video files, you will find that can't do it!

There is a good reason for this – Ubuntu, (as with Fedora, Suse Open Edition and any other completely free Linux distribution) cannot ship with software that is either not free, or contains a license which is considered commercial. It may not be illegal to distribute such software without a charge, but you may be required to accept a separate license from the authors of that software, or use the software on different terms than the rest of the system. In order to keep your distribution of Linux truly free, and the legalities of licensing a non-issue, this software is distributed separately from Ubuntu (as with other distributions).

You may have noticed when installing Ubuntu for the first time that there was a tick-box which asked if you wanted to install "Proprietary codecs", if you ticked the box then, the software you require to play most movie and music formats should already be installed, otherwise, Here is how to add support for these 'codecs' after installation of Ubuntu:

If you are using the Ubuntu Software Centre, simply search for **ubuntu-restricted-extras** and click 'Install'. Otherwise, if you wish to use the Synaptic Package Manager or 'apt install' at the command line, follow these steps:

Tux tip!

If you need a refresher on installing software, refer to [this guide](#) for detailed instructions on installing software for your particular distribution.

[See the official Ubuntu documentation for more info on restricted formats.](#)

Audio Players

As usual, both KDE and GNOME desktops have excellent offerings, and whilst there is a wealth of audio player software available for both platforms, I will limit the following reviews to just two players, one from each desktop platform: Rhythmbox (GNOME), and Amarok (KDE).

GNOME Music and Rhythmbox

Rhythmbox and its little sister, GNOME Music is one of the many audio apps available for Linux both built with the GNOME aesthetic in mind. Both are fairly similar in interface to iTunes, it allows you to listen and organise all your music on your PC. Rhythmbox is a little more feature-rich and allows connecting your digital music player to upload/download music to. It also connects you to Internet radio stations, Podcasts. It has in-built support for playing, ripping and burning audio CDs.

[amarok](#)

Despite having a silly name, amarok is a great music player for KDE users (it can also be installed on any other desktop). Fans of iTunes will be immediately relieved to hear that it looks very like iTunes and syncs with your iPod/iPhone flawlessly.

It creates dynamic playlists too, like the party shuffle feature in iTunes, but better! amaroK features automatic CD cover finders for each album on your PC, so you know what the CD looks like when you play it. It also grabs the lyrics for every song you play on demand, as well as telling you pretty much all the info you would ever want to know about the band you are listening to, from Wikipedia. It also features a built in ID3 tag editor to sort out those rogue MP3s with invalid entries, and features MusicBrainz to take some of the guesswork out of it.